

BEETHOVEN, LUDWIG VAN



FROM HIS BIRTH in Bonn in 1770 to his death in Vienna in 1827, Ludwig van Beethoven's lifetime spanned a period of revolution and transformation. Despite a tragically unhappy life, beset with family problems and deafness, he became the major composer of his time. His symphonies, sonatas, and chamber music expanded the Classical forms, introducing exciting new musical ideas that ushered in the fiery Romantic style. Unlike previous composers, Beethoven tried to remain independent, writing for himself rather than for a single rich patron. Independence allowed him to develop his own personal expressive musical style.



B



Beethoven's birthplace

Early life

Beethoven was born in Bonn, Germany. His childhood was not a happy one. His father, himself a musician, forced Ludwig to practise and perform in public at an early age, hoping he would become a child prodigy. When his mother died and his father lost his job, young Ludwig had to provide for the whole family.

Vienna

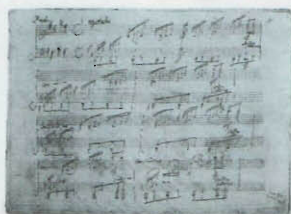
Beethoven's first visit to Vienna was cut short by his mother's illness, but he returned in 1792 to study with the composer Haydn. He soon established himself as a pianist and teacher, and settled there for the rest of his life. However, as his deafness worsened, he suffered from depressions and raging tempers, and withdrew from social life. He found consolation in composing music which expressed both his despair and his optimism and joy.



Beethoven's Broadwood grand piano

Notebooks

We can get a good idea of how Beethoven worked by looking at his manuscripts and notebooks. They show how he revised his work until he was completely satisfied with it. He wrote quickly and furiously, often crossing out and rewriting whole sections of the music.



Deafness

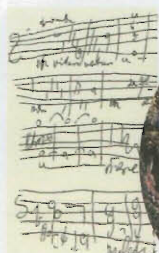
In his late twenties, Beethoven's hearing began to fail. By 1820, he was almost totally deaf. Unable to hear what he was playing, he could not earn a living from performing. Instead, he concentrated on composing.

Ear trumpets



The symphonies

Symphonies before Beethoven's time were orchestral works that followed a fairly set pattern, but, in his nine symphonies, Beethoven developed the form into a large and expressive work. From the third symphony, the *Eroica*, on, these works became longer and more adventurous, using new instruments and even vocalists and a choir in the ninth symphony.



Manuscript of the Pastoral symphony



Pastoral symphony

This symphony is unusual because it describes a scene: the countryside around Vienna where Beethoven loved to walk. It is full of the sounds of the country, including imitations of birdsong and a thunderstorm.



Eroica symphony

Beethoven originally dedicated this symphony to his hero Napoleon, but was disgusted when Napoleon proclaimed himself emperor. He scratched out the dedication, but kept the title *Eroica* (heroic).

Chamber music

Much of Beethoven's music is for small groups, such as the string quartet. This chamber music was often written for amateur players, but Beethoven found it provided an ideal way of expressing his new musical ideas.



LUDWIG VAN BEETHOVEN

1770 Born in Bonn, Germany

1792 Moves to Vienna, studies with Joseph Haydn

1796 Begins to go deaf

1802 Writes a letter, known as the "Heiligenstadt Testament", to his brothers, describing his unhappiness about his deafness

1803 *Eroica* symphony

1808 *Pastoral* symphony

1809 Piano Concerto No 5, "The Emperor"

1824 *Choral* symphony

1827 Dies in Vienna, Austria; some 10,000 people attend his funeral

FIND OUT
MORE

MOZART, WOLFGANG
AMADEUS

MUSIC

MUSICAL
INSTRUMENTS

NAPOLÉON ORCHESTRAS